

IK 558: Hinduism, Yoga and Ecology

Course Code : IK 558

Course Name : Hinduism, Yoga and Ecology

L-T-P-C : 3-0-0-3

Intended for : BTech/MTech/MS/MSc/MA/Ph.D

Prerequisite : None

Mutual Exclusion: None

Approval: 42nd Senate

Course Contents

- Session One: **Introduction to Environmental Issues:** We begin with a discussion of primary issues, resources, and pathways. We will examine issues including climate change, species extinctions, agricultural practices, and pollution of soil, water, and air, both in India and throughout the globe. We will examine texts including the Vedas, the Upaniṣads, and the philosophical and narrative Yoga literature. We will also introduce application of specific meditation and Yoga practices. (4 Hours)
- Session Two: **Pr̥thivī Sūkta, Earth Verses Hours:** In this session we will read the Pr̥thivī Sūkta, the portion of the Atharva Veda that praises the earth and invites sustained reflection on the importance of a healthy ecology. Its exuberant celebration of earth, water, fire, and air will be viewed through a series of photographs from all seven continents, inviting the students to participate in a viewing, a darśana, that breaks down barriers between self and others. (3 Hours)
- Session Three: **Sense of Place, India's Sacred Geography Hours:** Knowing one's eco-system, the source of one's water and food, and the rhythm of one's climate can be a starting point for recovering the sacred. For this session, students will be invited to reflect on their own geographic emplacement and will learn about the river, mountain, plateau, and coastal regions of India. Key texts will ground the discussion, including the horse sacrifice passage at the beginning of the Br̥hadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad and the story of Satyakama Jabala in the Chāndogya Upaniṣad. (3 Hours)
- Session Four: **Yoga Ethics, Yoga and Ecology Hours:** The Bhagavad-Gītā, in its articulation of the Yogas of Action (Karma), Knowledge (Jñāna), and devotion (Bhakti), provides a framework for taking up one's work in the world (Dharma, Loka-Saṅgraha) for the sake of the greater good. This session explores passages that describe all three paths as ways toward ecological repair of personhood and society. The Yoga Sūtra insists upon a stabilisation of one's ethics through the cultivation of nonviolence, truthfulness, not stealing, abstention, and minimisation of possessions. We will explore how these might be applied to current environmental difficulties. (3 Hours)
- Session Five: **Yogavāsiṣṭha and Tantra Hours:** We now turn our attention to how Tantra integrates bodily meditations with visualisation and mantra recitation. The Yogavāsiṣṭha (ca. 1000 CE) includes glorious descriptions of how the goddess (Devī) dances the natural world into being. It includes descriptions of progressive meditations on the five great elements as well as encouragement to take up one's responsibilities in the world whole-heartedly. (5 Hours)
- Session Six: **Animals Hours:** This session explores animal stories from the Pañca Tantra and the Yogavāsiṣṭha as well as stories of Ganesha and Hanuman. Animals suffuse the landscape of India. Every god and goddess has a companion animal. Diverse species of birds, mammals, and reptiles, large and

small, abound in rural and urban areas. Elephants and tigers will be discussed in light of the work of Vivek Menon of the Wildlife Trust of India. (3 Hours)

- **Session Seven: Eco-Activists Hours:** From the time of Gandhi, a constant refrain has been sung in India: live simply so that others may live! In this session, we will look at leaders inspired by his example who continue to advocate for environmental causes starting with an examination of the lifestyle advocated by Gandhi. These will include Anil Agarwal and Sunita Narain of the Centre for Science and Environment, Sunderlal Bahuguna, Vandana Shiva, and M.C. Mehta from India, and Laura Cornell, founder of the Green Yoga Association in the U.S. as well as mention of studies by scholars Pankaj Jain, George James, and David Haberman. (5 Hours)
- **Session Eight: Living Communities and Legislation Hours:** In this final session, we will discuss eco-friendly communities including Fireflies Ashram near Bengaluru, Navdanya near Dehradun, and Govardhan Eco-village near Mumbai as examples of how the highest lifestyle values of Hinduism and Yoga are taking shape for the purpose of environmental education and uplift. We will also include a survey of legislation around the globe that seeks to infuse law with the Gandhian principles of do-no-harm and hold-to-one's-truth. (4 Hours)

Laboratory/practical/tutorial Modules:

- NA

Textbooks:

1. Eknath Easwaran, **The Bhagavad-Gītā: A New Translation**, 2007.
2. Eknath Easwaran, **The Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali: A New Translation and Commentary**, 2009.
3. Arvind Sharma (Editor), **Dharma: Essential Readings on a Hindu Way of Life**, 2002.
4. David Kinsley, **Hinduism and Nature**, 2005.
5. Mircea Eliade, **Yoga and the Sacred Fire: A Study of the Origins and Practice of Yoga**, 1961.
6. Christopher Key Chapple, **Yoga and the Luminous: Patanjali's Spiritual Path**, 2008.

References:

1. Gavin Flood (Editor), **The Encyclopedia of Hinduism**, 2003.
2. Kim Knott, **Hinduism: A Very Short Introduction**, 2000.
3. Paul Williams, **Yoga: A Very Short Introduction**, 2008.
4. Stephen Knapp, **The Bhagavad-Gītā: A Beginner's Guide**, 2010.
5. Stephen Knapp, **The Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali: A Beginner's Guide**, 2011.